# SMART CITIES MISSION'S MARCH OF PROGRESS AGAINST ALL ODDS

The Smart Cities Mission in India is now in its ninth year. How is it doing, what challenges are there, and when will there be 100 smart cities in India?

India is predicted to have 60 cities with a population of more than 1 million people and 6 megacities with a population of more than 10 million by the year 2030. There will be great demand on cities to provide resources like water, infrastructure, transport, electricity, and healthcare due to the teeming population and continued trend of urban migration. This indicates that we must act quickly to improve the livability, sustainability, and resilience of our urban clusters.

## REPORT CARD FOR SMART CITIES

According to the most recent updates on the Smart Cities Mission, 66 of the 100 selected localities have still not achieved their physical goals eight years later. As a result, the mission's completion date has been moved up to July 2024.

However, according to the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), as on 20th September 2023, out of total budgeted 7,934 projects worth Rs. 1,71,000 crores, 6,091 projects worth Rs. 1,11,000 crores have been completed under the Smart Cities Mission (SCM). The differences between the two data points require closer examination. Requests were made from cities and Members of Parliament to give more time to complete the sanctioned projects.

On the one hand, 32 Smart Cities have completed more projects—in some cases, over four times the targeted amount—than those intended for SCM adoption. While the remaining 68 Smart communities have yet to complete their projects, some communities are not performing up to the mark.

## PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

According to the report's 18th Report of Standing Committee on Housing and Urban Affairs (2022-23), that ULBs (Urban Local Bodies) lack the necessary core competencies, skilled labour, and funding to complete urban infrastructure projects. However, the ULBs implemented focused programmes like AMRUT & SBM "reasonably well."

This demonstrates how small local organisations are unable to complete large-scale programmes like the Smart Cities Mission. Another problem is the general misunderstanding, which frequently results in projects being abandoned.

## REASONS FOR DELAY

The COVID-19 pandemic, multi-sectoral initiatives, local problems with land, labour, etc., according to the Committee, have all contributed to a delay in progress. The Committee discovered some irregularities in the implementation of smart city works in 2021 while reviewing the Smart Cities Mission, including repeated completion of the same task and work duplication, project costs that were higher than the going rate, frequent project cancellations following the conclusion of proposals, etc.

## TECHNOLOGY SOLUTIONS

Technology is essential for making cities smart, addressing issues like waste management, traffic management, and e-governance. Cities need to identify gaps in advanced technologies and encourage digital innovation to address digital talent, skill improvement, cybersecurity, and real-time project assessment. The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) is working with various agencies and technology providers to develop interoperable, scalable solutions for smart cities, enabling data sharing and other functionalities.

## GIS AIDS SMART CITIES

Geospatial visualisation, HD maps, interactive 3D models, and dashboards are essential tools for identifying problems, identifying pain areas, and coming up with new solutions. When it comes to Smart Cities, geospatial/maps are a game-changer because they offer real-time information about the citizens' information, wayfinding solutions for tourists or visitors visiting a particular place, the use of AI on airports for immigration and logistical purposes, citizen safety and security, and much more.

## TOP PERFORMING SMART CITIES

Smart cities like Bhubaneswar, Pune, Indore, Varanasi, Srinagar, Coimbatore Surat, and Kolkata are setting examples for other cities by implementing sustainable initiatives, updating infrastructure, and incorporating advanced technology.

# NEW TOWN KOLKATA GREEN SMART CITY

## TRENDSETTING URBAN LIVING

New Town Kolkata Green Smart City has created an entire ecosystem with an efficient Integrated Command & Control System, Co-living and Co-working, an Eco park, and a thriving IT & Fintech environment. Bengal Silicon Valley, a 250-acre New Town site in Kolkata Smart City, houses India's top three data centres. Several companies in data centres, software development, drones, robots, augmented reality, AI, IoT, data analytics, and research analytics have already invested in the region. Furthermore, The Bengal Silicon Valley tech area is embracing the manufacturing, assembly, and R&D of IT hardware and software co-designed systems. Significant allotees include Bengal Tech Park (a company of Adani Enterprises Ltd.), Reliance Corporate IT Park, L&T InfoTech, Tata Consultancy Services, Nxtra Data Limited (a subsidiary of Bharti Airtel) and many more. This region also has a growing Fintech business ecosystem.

The "Smart Connect", located in New Town, Kolkata, offers 53,000 square feet of rentable space for entrepreneurs, IT professionals, and software developers. It's near the Bengal Silicon IT Hub, shopping complexes, and the under-construction metro line, making it a prime location for co-working.

